

Chicago Tribune



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TUESDAY, MARCH 4, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

'COMED FOUR' CASE

Judge grants retrial on 4 counts

Convictions on number of other charges left intact

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

A federal judge Monday granted a new trial on some counts in the “ComEd Four” case alleging a wide-ranging plot to illegally influence then-House Speaker Michael Madigan, saying the Supreme Court’s ruling last year on a key bribery statute means the jury was not instructed properly.

In making his ruling, however, U.S. District Judge Manish Shah left intact the convictions on a number of other counts, including the lead count of conspiracy and charges alleging the defendants cooked ComEd’s books to hide the scheme.

It wasn’t immediately clear where the case will go next. The U.S. attorney’s office could seek to retry the defendants on the four bribery counts that were reversed, or appeal the ruling to the 7th U.S. Circuit Court of Appeals.

Assistant U.S. Attorney Amarjeet Bhachu told the judge he still needs to consult with his bosses, however he anticipated they will want to proceed to sentencing on the counts that remained, which could include long prison terms, rather than to retry the bribery counts.

Adding to the complexity was that four of the five counts that were left standing involve violations of the Foreign Corrupt Practices Act. Last month, President Donald Trump ordered a review of how the Justice Department enforces that law, which he said has been “stretched beyond proper bounds and abused in a manner that harms the interests of the United States.”

In the ComEd Four case, the four defendants were convicted

Turn to *Retrial*, Page 4



Liz Turnipseed, 43, stands Monday on Central Avenue near the scene where she was shot during the 2022 Fourth of July parade in Highland Park. She was preparing to testify in the trial before Robert Crimo III pleaded guilty. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Crimo enters guilty plea to 2022 Highland Park parade shooting

Mayor calls it ‘1,000%’ better than a trial

By Clifford Ward and
Caroline Kubzansky
Lake County News-Sun

Minutes before opening statements were set to begin in his murder trial Monday, Robert Crimo III pleaded guilty to opening fire on spectators at the 2022 Highland Park Fourth of July parade and killing seven people.

The plea was yet another unusual move from the 24-year-old gunman, who often skipped his court appearances and was accused of staring down the victim’s families during hear-

ings. Crimo nearly pleaded guilty to the mass shooting in June but changed his mind in court.

Crimo’s 11th-hour decision to plead guilty to 21 counts of first-degree murder and 48 counts of attempted murder short-circuited a trial that was expected to last up to five weeks. Instead, he will be sentenced April 23 for killing seven people, wounding 48 others and traumatizing an entire community.

Crimo’s mother, Denise Pesina, who was in the gallery for the proceedings, created an outburst after the plea was announced. She

was brought before Judge Victoria Rossetti, who warned her to remain silent if she wanted to stay in the courtroom.

When Pesina left the Lake County courthouse a short time later, she screamed at journalists about deporting immigrants but refused to answer questions about her son.

Highland Park Mayor Nancy Roterer, who was in court, said the guilty plea was the best outcome for victims and their families, calling it “1,000%” better than a trial.

“I think, at this moment, we’re all just sort of surprised and relieved that they don’t have to

experience the unbelievable pain of reliving this experience for the next three to five weeks,” she said.

Several victims and their families remain in civil litigation related to the shooting, including against Crimo III, his father, gun manufacturer Smith & Wesson and the gun shops that helped Crimo III get his weapons. Several lawsuits also have been filed against the Illinois State Police for approving Crimo’s Firearm Owner’s Identification card application despite concerns he was a danger to public safety.

Crimo’s father, Robert Crimo

Turn to *Crimo*, Page 4



A building in Hoffman Estates temporarily stores records and gifts from the Obama administration. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

DOGE says it’s closing Obama library site in Hoffman Estates

Federal officials had announced in 2024 lease there was ending

By Brian J. Rogal
Chicago Tribune

President Donald Trump’s administration canceled the lease for the Barack Obama Presidential Library in northwest suburban Hoffman Estates, one of many federal leases and contracts

recently terminated, according to a list published by Elon Musk’s Department of Government Efficiency.

But the cancellation may have little impact. Federal officials who run the temporary facility said in mid-2024 that they planned to exit the lease and move the library to a permanent, out-of-state location this year.

Critics say it’s part of DOGE’s “slash and burn” strategy toward federal contracts and leases, either

canceling many without necessary planning or inflating the amount of spending cuts by including contracts already paid off or expiring.

“It’s possible (DOGE) has some particular malice toward the real estate holding the archives for the last really popular two-term president,” said Charles Tiefer, a retired University of Baltimore law professor and government

Turn to *Library*, Page 2

Trump OKs Mexico and Canada tariffs

US taxes of 25% to start Tuesday with ‘no room’ for delay

By Josh Boak, Zeke Miller and Rob Gillies
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump said Monday that 25% taxes on imports from Mexico and Canada would start Tuesday, sparking renewed fears of a North American trade war that already showed signs of pushing up inflation and hindering growth.

“Tomorrow — tariffs 25% on Canada and 25% on Mexico. And that’ll start,” Trump told reporters in the Roosevelt Room of the White House. “They’re going to have to have a tariff.”

Trump has said the tariffs are to force the two U.S. neighbors to step up their fight against fentanyl trafficking and stop illegal immigration. But Trump has also indicated that he wants to eliminate the Americas’ trade imbalances as well and push

more factories to relocate in the United States.

His comments quickly rattled the U.S. stock market, with the S&P 500 index closing down 1.8%. It’s a sign of the political and economic risks that Trump feels compelled to take, given the possibility of higher inflation and the possible demise of a decadeslong trade partnership with Mexico and Canada as the tariffs would go into effect at 12:01 a.m. Tuesday.

Yet the Trump administration remains confident that tariffs are the best choice to boost U.S. manufacturing and attract foreign investment.

Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick said Monday that the computer chipmaker TSMC had expanded its investment in the United States because of the possibility of separate 25% tariffs.

In February, Trump put a 10% tariff on imports from China. He reemphasized Monday that the rate would double to 20%

Turn to *Tariffs*, Page 4

Mayoral run? Rahm doesn’t rule it out

Rahm Emanuel is not ruling out making another bid for the city’s top job or even seeking the Illinois governorship.

Chicagoland, Page 3

